

CLASS 10 CBSE ENGLISH - FIRST FLIGHT

Chapter 2: Nelson Mandela: Long Walk to Freedom • Poem: Fire and Ice

Study Material Includes

NCERT exercise solutions • Oral Comprehension Check • Thinking About the Text • Thinking About Language • Paragraph-wise explanation • Themes • Character sketch • Important quotations • Word meanings • Poetic devices • Extract-based questions • Short & long answers • Value-based questions • Additional CBSE-oriented questions

PART I - NELSON MANDELA: LONG WALK TO FREEDOM

Nelson Rolihlahla Mandela

A. Oral Comprehension Check - NCERT

1. Where did the ceremonies take place? Can you name any public buildings in India that are made of sandstone?

Answer: The ceremonies took place in the sandstone amphitheatre formed by the Union Buildings in Pretoria. In India, examples of important sandstone buildings include the Red Fort and many historic structures in Rajasthan and Delhi.

2. Can you say how 10 May is an 'autumn day' in South Africa?

Answer: South Africa lies in the Southern Hemisphere, where the seasons are opposite to those in the Northern Hemisphere. Therefore, May is an autumn month there.

3. At the beginning of his oath-taking ceremony, Mr de Klerk spoke of his country. What did he say?

Answer: Mr de Klerk acknowledged the historic change taking place in South Africa and the presence of distinguished international leaders. His participation represented the transition from apartheid to democratic government.

4. What 'twin obligations' does Mandela mention?

Answer: Mandela mentions an obligation to his family and an obligation to his people, community and country. Under apartheid, fulfilling his wider social and political obligation was extremely difficult.

5. What was the effect of decades of oppression on Mandela?

Answer: Decades of oppression transformed Mandela from a frightened young man into a courageous leader. The suffering around him strengthened his determination to fight injustice and taught him the true meaning of courage.

6. Why were two national anthems sung?

Answer: The two national anthems symbolised reconciliation and unity between communities that had previously been separated by apartheid. Their singing represented the beginning of a new, democratic South Africa.

B. Thinking About the Text - NCERT

1. Why did the inauguration ceremony take place in the amphitheatre formed by the Union Buildings?

Answer: The Union Buildings had been associated with the former white government. Holding the inauguration there symbolised that the old system had been replaced by a democratic government representing all South Africans.

2. What does Mandela mean when he says he is 'simply the sum of all those African patriots'?

Answer: Mandela humbly acknowledges that his achievements were made possible by generations of African patriots who sacrificed their lives, freedom and happiness for justice. He sees himself as a product of their collective struggle.

3. How does Mandela describe the system of apartheid?

Answer: Apartheid was a system of racial discrimination and domination. The white minority controlled the country and denied the black majority and other non-white communities equal political, social and economic rights.

4. What ideals did Mandela set for the future of South Africa?

Answer: He wanted a democratic and non-racial society based on equality, freedom, justice and human dignity. He hoped that the country would be free from poverty, discrimination, oppression and fear.

5. What did Mandela say about courage?

Answer: Mandela says that courage is not the absence of fear. A courageous person experiences fear but conquers it and continues to act despite it.

6. What is the meaning of 'freedom' for Mandela?

Answer: Freedom means much more than personal liberty. It means that every person should have the right to live with dignity, equality and security. Mandela's idea of freedom includes the freedom of the entire community.

7. How did Mandela's idea of freedom change as he grew older?

Answer: As a child, Mandela thought freedom meant ordinary personal activities such as playing, running and living without restrictions. As he grew older, he realised that black South Africans were denied fundamental rights. His idea therefore changed from personal freedom to collective freedom.

C. Thinking About Language - NCERT

1. What words in the text refer to discrimination and oppression?

Answer: Important expressions include apartheid, racial domination, racial discrimination, oppression, deprivation, suffering and exploitation. These words describe the unjust conditions created by the apartheid system.

2. What does 'rainbow gathering' suggest?

Answer: It suggests a gathering of people of different races, cultures and communities. The expression symbolises unity in diversity and the hope of a harmonious South Africa.

3. Explain 'an extraordinary human disaster' and 'glorious human achievement'.

Answer: 'An extraordinary human disaster' refers to the suffering and injustice caused by apartheid. 'Glorious human achievement' refers to the establishment of democracy and the victory of equality and freedom over racial domination.

4. Use liberation, emancipation, oppression and subjugation in sentences.

Answer: Liberation: The country celebrated its liberation from unjust rule.

Emancipation: Education can contribute to the emancipation of disadvantaged people.

Oppression: The people protested against years of oppression.

Subjugation: The movement sought to end racial subjugation.

D. Paragraph-wise Explanation

The inauguration and the new South Africa

Answer: Mandela describes the historic inauguration as a moment when people from many countries gathered to witness the birth of a democratic South Africa. The setting and ceremony symbolise the end of racial domination.

Mandela's tribute to freedom fighters

Answer: He remembers generations of patriots who sacrificed their lives and freedom. Mandela does not claim the achievement as his alone; he considers himself part of a much larger historical struggle.

Courage and fear

Answer: Mandela explains that brave people are not free from fear. Instead, they learn to conquer fear. His own experiences taught him that courage is the ability to act despite danger.

The twin obligations

Answer: Mandela explains that a person has responsibilities towards family as well as society. Apartheid made it difficult for him to fulfil his obligation to his people, because opposing the system could result in punishment and imprisonment.

Freedom and interdependence

Answer: Mandela gradually realised that the freedom of one individual is connected to the freedom of others. A person cannot be completely free when the community remains oppressed.

The future vision

Answer: Mandela hopes for a South Africa where people of all races can live together with equal rights, dignity and opportunities. He emphasises reconciliation rather than revenge.

E. Character Sketches

Nelson Mandela

Answer: Mandela is presented as courageous, humble, patriotic, disciplined and committed to justice. He respects the sacrifices of earlier patriots and does not consider himself the sole hero. He also values reconciliation and believes in equality and human dignity.

Mandela as a leader

Answer: As a leader, Mandela combines courage with humility. He accepts responsibility but recognises the contribution of others. His vision is inclusive: he wants freedom and dignity for all South Africans rather than power for one group.

F. Themes

Freedom

Answer: The chapter shows that freedom is a basic human right and that genuine freedom must include the freedom of others.

Courage

Answer: Mandela defines courage as triumph over fear rather than absence of fear.

Equality

Answer: The chapter condemns racial discrimination and presents democracy as a system in which people have equal rights.

Sacrifice

Answer: Generations of patriots suffered and sacrificed for freedom.

Reconciliation

Answer: Mandela's vision focuses on building a shared future rather than continuing racial conflict.

Human dignity

Answer: The chapter repeatedly emphasises the right of every person to live with respect and dignity.

G. Additional Theoretical Questions

1. Why is 10 May 1994 important in South African history?

Answer: It was the day Nelson Mandela was inaugurated as the first democratically elected President of South Africa. It marked a major transition to democratic government after apartheid.

2. Why does Mandela call apartheid an extraordinary human disaster?

Answer: Because it created systematic racial injustice, denied millions of people basic rights and caused long-lasting suffering.

3. Why does Mandela say that both the oppressed and the oppressor are robbed of freedom?

Answer: The oppressed lose their rights and dignity, while the oppressor becomes trapped in prejudice, hatred and an unjust system. Mandela believes liberation restores humanity to both.

4. What does Mandela mean by ‘the chains on any one of my people were the chains on all of them’?

Answer: He means that the loss of freedom suffered by one person affects the dignity and freedom of the entire community.

5. Why does Mandela refer to himself as the ‘sum’ of African patriots?

Answer: He recognises that his achievements grew out of the sacrifices and struggles of many earlier freedom fighters.

6. Why is the title ‘Long Walk to Freedom’ appropriate?

Answer: Freedom was not achieved suddenly. Mandela and generations of South Africans endured years of struggle, sacrifice and oppression before democracy was established.

H. Important Quotations & Meanings

“Courage was not the absence of fear, but the triumph over it.”

Answer: True courage means overcoming fear and doing what is necessary despite it.

“No one is born hating another person.”

Answer: Hatred is learned; therefore, people can also learn love, tolerance and respect.

“For to be free is not merely to cast off one’s chains.”

Answer: Real freedom requires freedom and dignity for others as well as oneself.

“I am the sum of all those African patriots...”

Answer: Mandela acknowledges the contribution of generations of freedom fighters.

PART II - FIRE AND ICE

Robert Frost

A. Stanza-wise Explanation

Lines 1-2: Fire or desire

Answer: The poet says that some people believe the world will end in fire. Fire symbolises desire, greed, passion, anger and uncontrolled human craving. The poet agrees that destructive desire could be powerful enough to cause great destruction.

Lines 3-4: Ice or hatred

Answer: Other people believe the world will end in ice. Ice symbolises hatred, coldness, indifference and emotional hostility. The poet says that he has experienced enough hatred to know that it too can destroy.

Final lines: Fire and ice

Answer: The poet concludes that either fire or ice would be sufficient to destroy the world. The poem therefore presents uncontrolled desire and hatred as equally destructive human emotions.

B. Thinking About the Poem - NCERT

1. There are many ideas about how the world will end. Do you think the world will end someday? Have you ever thought what the world will be like then?

Answer: The poem uses the end of the world as a metaphor for destructive human emotions. Whether or not the literal world ends is uncertain, but the poem suggests that uncontrolled desire, hatred and conflict can destroy human relationships and societies.

2. For Frost, what do 'fire' and 'ice' stand for?

Answer: 'Fire' stands for desire, greed, passion and uncontrolled craving. 'Ice' stands for hatred, coldness, indifference and emotional hostility. Both represent destructive human tendencies.

3. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem?

Answer: The poem follows the rhyme scheme ABAABCBCB.

4. What does 'suffice' mean in the poem?

Answer: 'Suffice' means 'be enough'. The poet says that either fire or ice would be enough to bring about destruction.

5. What is the central message of the poem?

Answer: The poem warns that destructive emotions can have devastating consequences. Desire and hatred may appear different, but both can lead to destruction.

C. Poetic Devices - Fire and Ice

Device	Explanation
Rhyme	The rhyme scheme is ABAABCBCB.
Symbolism	Fire symbolises desire and passion; ice symbolises hatred and emotional coldness.
Alliteration	Repeated consonant sounds add emphasis and rhythm.
Anaphora/Repetition	The repeated use of words such as 'Some say' gives structure and emphasis.
Antithesis	Fire and ice are opposing images representing two different destructive forces.
Personification/Metaphorical imagery	The abstract emotions are presented through concrete natural elements.
Enjambment	Several lines continue into the next without a full stop, creating flow.

D. Central Idea & Themes - Fire and Ice

Central idea

Answer: The poem uses fire and ice as symbols of destructive human emotions. Uncontrolled desire and hatred can both cause enormous destruction.

Theme of desire

Answer: Desire can become destructive when it turns into greed, selfishness or uncontrolled craving.

Theme of hatred

Answer: Hatred is compared to ice because it can make people emotionally cold and can destroy relationships and communities.

Theme of human responsibility

Answer: The poem encourages readers to recognise destructive emotions and control them before they cause harm.

E. Important Words & Meanings

Desire

Answer: A strong wish or craving for something.

Favour

Answer: Support or preference.

Perish

Answer: To die or be destroyed.

Suffice

Answer: To be enough.

Hatred

Answer: A strong feeling of dislike or hostility.

Destruction

Answer: The act of causing severe damage or ruin.

F. Additional Questions - Fire and Ice

1. Why does Frost use fire and ice instead of directly naming emotions?

Answer: Fire and ice are vivid natural images. They make abstract emotions such as desire and hatred easier to visualise and remember.

2. Why does the poet agree that fire could destroy the world?

Answer: He has experienced desire and recognises its destructive potential. Uncontrolled desire can lead to greed, conflict and violence.

3. Why does ice represent hatred?

Answer: Ice is cold and hard, so it effectively represents emotional coldness, hostility and the absence of warmth or affection.

4. What makes the poem powerful despite its short length?

Answer: Its brevity, symbolism, simple language, strong contrasts and philosophical idea give it considerable impact.

5. Is fire more destructive than ice in the poem?

Answer: The poet does not present one as definitively more destructive. He says that either one would be sufficient. Both represent destructive emotions.

G. Extract-Based Questions

“Some say the world will end in fire / Some say in ice.”

What do fire and ice symbolise?

Answer: Fire symbolises desire; ice symbolises hatred or emotional coldness.

What poetic device is central here?

Answer: Symbolism and antithesis are central.

What contrast is created?

Answer: The contrast is between heat and cold, and between desire and hatred.

“I think I know enough of hate / To say that for destruction ice / Is also great”

What has the poet experienced?

Answer: The poet has experienced hatred.

What does ice represent?

Answer: Ice represents hatred and emotional coldness.

What does ‘great’ suggest?

Answer: It suggests that hatred is powerful enough to cause destruction.

H. Combined CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

1. How does ‘Fire and Ice’ connect with the ideas of ‘Nelson Mandela: Long Walk to Freedom’?

Answer: Mandela speaks about the destructive effects of hatred and racial domination and advocates equality and reconciliation. Frost presents desire and hatred as destructive forces through the symbols of fire and ice. Both texts therefore draw attention to the danger of destructive human emotions, although they approach the idea in different forms.

2. Explain the significance of fire and ice as symbols.

Answer: Fire represents uncontrolled desire, passion and greed, while ice represents hatred, emotional coldness and indifference. Both can become destructive when allowed to dominate human behaviour.

3. Why is Mandela’s definition of courage important?

Answer: It presents courage as a realistic human quality. Fear is natural, but courageous people overcome it and continue to act according to their principles.

4. How does Mandela’s vision differ from a desire for revenge?

Answer: Mandela seeks equality, democracy and reconciliation rather than continued racial conflict. His vision is based on a shared future and dignity for all.

5. What common moral lesson can be drawn from both texts?

Answer: Human beings must control destructive emotions and work towards dignity, equality, understanding and peaceful coexistence.

I. Value-Based Questions

1. How can students apply Mandela’s idea of courage in school life?

Answer: They can face difficulties honestly, speak against unfair behaviour respectfully, accept challenges and continue working despite fear of failure.

2. How can uncontrolled desire become harmful?

Answer: When desire turns into greed or selfishness, it can lead people to ignore ethics, exploit others and create conflict.

3. How can hatred be reduced in society?

Answer: Respectful communication, empathy, education, equal treatment and opportunities for cooperation can help reduce prejudice and hostility.

4. Why is reconciliation important after conflict?

Answer: Reconciliation helps people move beyond past divisions and build a more peaceful and cooperative future.

J. Very Short Questions

Who wrote 'Nelson Mandela: Long Walk to Freedom'?

Answer: Nelson Rolihlahla Mandela.

When was Mandela inaugurated as President?

Answer: 10 May 1994.

Where did the inauguration take place?

Answer: At the Union Buildings in Pretoria.

What was apartheid?

Answer: A system of institutionalised racial segregation and discrimination in South Africa.

What are Mandela's 'twin obligations'?

Answer: His obligations to his family and to his people/community.

What does Mandela say courage is?

Answer: The triumph over fear.

Who wrote 'Fire and Ice'?

Answer: Robert Frost.

What does fire symbolise?

Answer: Desire, greed, passion or uncontrolled craving.

What does ice symbolise?

Answer: Hatred, coldness and emotional hostility.

What is the rhyme scheme of 'Fire and Ice'?

Answer: ABAABCBCB.

What does 'suffice' mean?

Answer: To be enough.

K. Important Quotations & Meanings

"It was a crime against humanity."

Answer: The statement conveys the severe moral and human injustice associated with racial oppression.

"The oppressed and the oppressor alike are robbed of their humanity."

Answer: Oppression harms both those who suffer from it and those who participate in it.

"For to be free is not merely to cast off one's chains."

Answer: Freedom is meaningful only when people can live with dignity and when others are free as well.

"Some say the world will end in fire."

Answer: Fire introduces the symbolic idea of desire as a destructive force.

"I think I know enough of hate."

Answer: The poet draws upon human experience to present hatred as another powerful destructive force.

L. CBSE Answer-Writing Tips

For 2-3 marks

Answer: Answer directly, include the key textual idea and support it with one relevant detail.

For 5-6 marks

Answer: Start with the main argument, develop it with textual evidence, and end with the broader theme or message.

For poetry questions

Answer: Mention the relevant poetic device, explain its meaning in context and connect it to the poem's central idea.

For value-based questions

Answer: Link the text with a clear value such as courage, equality, empathy, self-control, tolerance or reconciliation.